

The NLP Approach to Coaching

Bruce Grimley

INTRODUCTION

Neuro-linguistic programming (NLP) does not have an explicitly articulated theoretical foundation. Despite this, however, most coaches routinely make use of the models that have been developed by NLP practitioners. NLP is thus acknowledged as a practical discipline, where utility, rather than theoretical elegance, is foremost.

Increasingly, authors such as Linder-Pelz and Hall (2007) are beginning to identify the psychological theories that are central to NLP and argue that it is proper to recognize NLP's roots in established psychological strands. The University of Surrey has recognized this gap and in July 2008 hosted the first international neuro-linguistic programming research conference. A close reading of the literature reveals that in fact there are a host of psychological concepts that underpin NLP, many of which have been independently tested.

This chapter begins by exploring NLP's inception and its links to behaviourism and cognitivism. It then examines the language and operating principles of NLP before looking at the approach in relation to a coaching context.

Origins of NLP

NLP began in the early 1970s at the University of Santa Cruz when Richard Bandler contacted John Grinder, an associate professor of linguistics, and was invited to attend a Gestalt workshop with the aim of observing the self-taught expertise of Fritz Perls and developing a model

(Bostic St Clair & Grinder, 2001). One of the main assumptions here, and the one which underpins NLP, was that whoever we are and whatever we do, there is a consistent internal ordering and structuring of our perceiving, thinking, feeling and behaving. By modelling the processes and patterns used by experts, such as Perls and Virginia Satir, consistent results could be obtained. This is made clear in one of the earliest books on NLP: 'Neuro-Linguistic Programming is the discipline whose domain is the structure of subjective experience. It makes no commitment to theory, but rather has the status of a model – a set of procedures whose usefulness, not truthfulness is to be the measure of its worth' (Dilts, Grinder, Bandler, & DeLozier, 1980). Thus it is our own ordering and structuring of the world that achieves results.

From a psychological perspective these assumptions are shared with constructivist psychology. The NLP coach assumes that coachees' internal processes are psychologically channelled by the way in which they anticipate events (Kelly, 1963), and this anticipation is a function of their experience in the world and the maps they have consequently built. Explicitly, the link to a constructive perspective with NLP is made through Korzybski (1933, 1994): 'A map is not the territory it represents, but if correct, it has a similar structure to the territory, which accounts for its usefulness'.

Behaviourism and cognitivism

The eclectic nature of NLP continues in that not only is it constructivist in nature but it also has much in common with behaviourist psychology. Like behaviorism, NLP does not insist on an archaeological, depth approach that explores past events and feelings. Neither does it call for a conscious understanding on the part of the individual undergoing the change. Rather, much of the work is done through classical conditioning. NLP calls this process anchoring, and extends associations to both internal mental and external events. When these associations are individually made in the presence of emotional arousal, they form rudimentary, sensory based templates and synesthesias that form the basis of our experience and our individual creation of meaning. This gives birth to emotional memories that are not represented in the cortical areas of the brain in a coherent and narrative way.

Paradoxically, even though NLP may align itself with behaviourist psychology it is also very different in that, unlike behaviourism, NLP is very interested in what goes on inside the brain. It therefore has a basis in cognitive psychology. It is interested in how individuals create their maps of the world. It is also interested in language.

The result of Grinder's modelling of Perls and Satir was the Meta Model (Bandler & Grinder, 1975a, 1976). When Grinder came out of the 'know nothing state' (a form of deep trance identification used for modelling), and began to analyse the linguistic patterns produced through the modelling process he immediately recognized the similarity with transformational grammar: Bostic St Clair and Grinder (2001) confirm that the single most pervasive influence in NLP is the paradigm that was current in linguistics at the time of the creation of NLP.

Transformational grammar suggests that sensory experience is transformed into conscious understanding through language, and often the language we use deletes and distorts aspects of the original experience. Language also represents the many unconscious generalizations from early experiences to other similar experiences, so that the maps we bring to novel experience sometimes distort that experience based upon previous learnings. In coaching, precise meta-model questions assist the coachee in understanding the nature of their distortions, deletions and generalizations. Once they do this, they are then in a position to alter hitherto unconscious assumptions which they have been carrying about with them, and which formed the basis of behaviour in a particular context.

The Milton Model

Another early NLP exemplar was the psychiatrist Dr Milton Erickson. Bateson, who was mentor to both Bandler and Grinder, suggested that he would be worth modelling. The model that was developed has come to be known as 'The Milton Model' (Bandler & Grinder, 1975b; Grinder, DeLozier, & Bandler, 1977). The assumption Erickson had concerning people was that they already had the resources to make their desired change, however, these resources were often located unconsciously, and they did not know how to access them. Erickson's work was characterized by an approach called utilization, which advocated accepting and amplifying the client's process for therapeutic change.

The essence of change from the Milton Model perspective is that the client's reality is self-generated through unconscious circular processes. These self-reflexive processes can result in either expanded circles of autonomy if the personal reality is appreciated, or vicious circles of unchanging patterns if the 'reality' and its commensurate experience is not valued and is actively resisted. The process of utilization thus encourages the client to value and appreciate all their experience, and with such acceptance comes change.

TASKS AND GOALS

The goal of NLP coaching is to maximize clients' resourcefulness and increase the choice they have in a given context. In order for individuals to develop it is useful from an NLP perspective if they can begin to appreciate how they create their own reality and thus their own possibilities as well as limitations. One popular saying within the NLP community is 'there are no resistant clients ... only inflexible coaches'. From an NLP perspective then, whoever comes to coaching, irrespective of whether they share NLP presuppositions or not, should be amenable to personal development of some kind. The NLP coach will have the acuity to notice the structure of their experience and how they consistently repeat their self-defeating patterns. The coachee often is unaware of these patterns, and whether the NLP coach decides to bring them to the conscious

attention of the coachee or whether they work with their client at an unconscious level is of secondary importance.

The key to NLP coaching therefore is to develop and increase self awareness to the extent that the coachee recognizes that, whenever they are stuck, it is only because of the way they are construing the world. Their inner powers of thought and emotion, and outer powers of language and behaviour, can be configured in a variety of ways. Through developing self awareness these coachees can then understand what it is that needs to change in order to move on. The array of models and techniques of NLP coaching can benefit coachees in achieving the task of creating autonomy rather than dependence on the coach. As they begin to value their experiences, rather than deny them, they learn to appreciate them as a resource through which they can be developed effectively.

ESSENTIAL PROCESSES AND DYNAMICS

Using the main pillars of NLP; Outcome, Acuity, Flexibility (O'Connor & Seymour, 1995), the NLP coach focuses on three main questions: Does the client know specifically what they want? Can they keep their senses open so they know what they are presently getting? Do they have the flexibility to keep changing till they get what they want? Many coaches will see an overall similarity here with the GROW model (Goal, Reality, Options, Will/Wrap up).

NLP recognizes that in order for desired change to occur, the conscious mind does not really need to be involved. Flexibility within the coaching client can often be accomplished in a covert way. In order to address the ethical objections that could arise from such an approach, the NLP coach will act in at least two ways. During their initial contracting they will make it clear that their coaching style operates in this way, in order to diminish the amount of resistance and speed up the coaching process. Depending upon their style they would obtain written consent to such an approach or at least verbal consent from the coachee. Second, the NLP coach will only work in a process-oriented way. What this means is that no content is introduced by the coach. This is important because often a coachee will request coaching at challenging times in their life and so may be more suggestible than usual and amenable to subtle introductions of content from the coach.

An example of the introduction of content would be:

Client: 'I feel really angry about that'

Coach: 'and I guess that means you are pretty frustrated too?'

The association between anger and frustration, even though well documented in the psychology literature, may not have even been there for this particular client before the coach introduced it.

Bostic St Clair and Grinder, (2001: 198–9) summarize what they believe to be the core NLP processes:

1. The Meta Model is designed to verbally challenge the mapping between first access to the outside world through our senses and our linguistically mediated mental maps.

2. Operations define over-representational systems and their sub-modalities.
3. Reframing patterns, so that representations are placed in a different cognitive structure.
4. Anchoring, so that undifferentiated groupings of representations are brought together for purposes of integration.
5. The Milton model, where representations are shifted using linguistically mediated maps without the need to map those representations into the client's conscious understanding.

ROLE OF THE COACH AND RELATIONSHIP WITH A CLIENT

NLP coaching is a very fluid process which starts with the establishment of rapport and the coach uses this rapport to facilitate the natural process of change. This is done by working at the *level of process*. If the client is using visual predicates in their language then the coach will match that visual process by choosing visual predicates oneself. If the coachee's language is punctuated with generalizations then so will the coach's language. In this way, essentially the coach is saying: 'I am like you'. As people tend to like people who are like them, a natural rapport is then built up. Without rapport the coach cannot proceed. Once rapport is established, the coach is in a position to assist the coachee in establishing well-formed outcomes. At this stage the coach is operating as a sounding board for the coachee. Using the Meta Model, questions can be asked to ensure the outcome can indeed be tested and verified so that the coachee knows that he or she has been successful.

At this stage the NLP coach is often required to be supportive. When evidence of limiting beliefs appear, for example metaphor can be used to unconsciously provide a resourcefulness to be drawn on at a later time. Because NLP coaches work 'underneath the radar' so to speak, very often coachees will recognize that change is happening in their life but would not know why. They may not even attribute it to the coaching process and may put it down to the variable of time and natural resourcefulness kicking in, and may rationalize that the coaching was not even necessary. This is characteristic of the very fluid and flexible approach that arises from NLP coaching.

METHODS AND TECHNIQUES FOR FACILITATION OF CHANGE AND DEVELOPMENT

NLP is replete with coaching strategies/techniques which have been developed since the 1970s. In this section we will look briefly at nine different techniques:

1. Matching and pacing

Matching is a rapport-building technique involving feeding back the behavioural patterns of the person being coached. It is recognized that people who are really 'getting on' are almost in a

dance. If one person touches their ear, often within a few minutes the other person will match with a hand to face gesture of some kind. Similarly, pacing is feeding back the cognitive patterns of the person being coached. If for example the coachee talks exclusively about the future and does so using abstract language, then those are the patterns fed back to them by the coach.

Critics of NLP sometimes suggest that matching and pacing is being false or incongruent. However, NLP practitioners see these as building bridges so that the map of the coachee can be more fully appreciated. It has to be said that coaches can match or pace someone who is quite different from them, but it will require more effort than matching and pacing someone who is similar. Matching and pacing is the precursor for leading. A very good indicator as to whether or not the coach is matching and pacing effectively is when they do something differently from how the coachee usually does it, and after a time lag, the coachee follows them.

2. Leading

The purpose of leading is to widen coachees' repertoires and to provide them with greater choice in their life. In order to know what set of skills or state they require, coaches must of course have established what their coachees' well-formed outcome is. For example, if they wish to network more effectively, and during the establishment of rapport the coach has noticed that the coachee is moving away from undesirable situations rather than moving towards desirable ones, the following dialogue might be useful:

Coach: You have told me how you would rather stay in and have other people contact you, and you have also let me know about the anxiety you feel in talking to others about what you do. However, try to see yourself and your business, which is important to you, in five years' time. If you stay in waiting for others to make the move, imagine what that does for your bank balance. Looking at yourself in this situation from that place in five years' time, what could be the first thing you do now to make a difference?

Assuming agreement concerning well formed outcomes has been established, the 'away from' pattern would be activated by this dialogue; the coachee being supported by the coach will naturally be led into a process whereby they search for the most appropriate action in the immediate present to change their situation. This leading process however, would not be effective if the matching and pacing were not present, and during the rapport building process the appropriate cognitive filters had not been picked up on in order to be fed back to the coachee.

3. Well-formed outcomes

To make progress the coachee needs to know what it is they want and NLP approaches can support how they do this in a number of ways that ensure that success is maximized.

a) Stated in the positive

First, a coachee's outcome has to be formulated in positive terms. This is because if it is stated in the negative ('I don't want to be commercially isolated') then in order for them to process

this outcome, they have to have in their mind the idea of being commercially isolated; this will be a psychological barrier to what they wish. According to the Coue's (1923) law of reversed effect, the harder one tries to do something the less chance one has of succeeding. This is because whenever the imagination and the will are pitted against each other, it is the imagination that wins the day (Kroger, 1977). If coachees have to process and represent to themselves the experience of being commercially isolated, then, however hard they attempt to use their conscious mind to become otherwise, they will behave in a manner conducive to being commercially isolated. Brooks (1922), who was Coue's student, took the idea further, suggesting that every idea of the conscious mind may become accepted by the unconscious. From there it would be transformed into reality and therefore become a permanent element in life. This works in a similar way to the Pygmalion effect, where expectations influence the outcome in the direction of those expectations without any conscious awareness. Ideally, the outcome needs to be stated in the positive at a conscious level so that it may be supported by the unconscious mind with an equally positive belief and intention.

b) Sensory based

Making a goal 'sensory based' is similar to using the measurable and specific items in the well known SMART acronym. If outcomes are stated in vague abstract language, then it is not possible to imagine achieving the outcome. The goal of being successful tells us little until we break it down into specific sensory-based language which can be unequivocally understood and, most importantly, assimilated by the unconscious mind of the coachee. Evidence from experimental psychology comes from the Encoding Specificity principle (Tulving & Thompson, 1973 [as cited in Smith, Morton, & Oakley, 1998]). Internal and external cues present during the encoding of material are represented in the resulting memory traces. If such cues are present during retrieval then retrieval will be enhanced. Conversely, there is a reduction in retrieval when the encoding context is removed. This is a bit like the home advantage in sports competition. The cues which make up the context during encoding are all sensory based. In addition, the coach encourages coachees to retrieve their well formed outcomes regularly and test whether or not they are moving towards them, ensuring that they are defined within a context which is sensory based.

c) Chunk size

In another comparison with SMART, chunk size would be most similar to the Achievable and Realistic items. 'Changing the world for the better', for example is a vague aim, but it is also a very large chunk. Even though this outcome may be possible, in order to generate action the outcome needs to be of sufficient chunk size to enable coachees to proceed immediately in the present. Conversely, if they are fully capable and confident, but lack motivation, it is beneficial for them to 'chunk up', so that their specific actions can be related to higher, more abstract ideals and beliefs that drive their behaviour through an association with their personal values.

d) Ecology

Ecology does not really have a counterpart in the SMART model. It refers more to emotions. When setting well-formed outcomes, it is important that there are no verbal or non-verbal ‘buts’. It is also important that the outcome is in line with the coachees’ beliefs, values and identity. When checking for ecology, one might find that the outcome is good but the timing is wrong. One might also find while the outcome fits with personal beliefs, values and identity, there is a lack of confidence concerning capability. Sometimes, what prevents a successful ecology check is that coachees might feel that while they are gaining something by achieving their outcome, it is at the expense of losing something of value. It would be important then to revise the well formed outcome to include what is being left behind. As can be seen, setting outcomes is important to the beginning of the coaching process; however, it can also be a change process in itself.

e) Time frame

The time frame assists in motivating the coachee to develop a structure within which to work. If there is no time frame then often a consistent reply is ‘yes, I am working on this’ – ad infinitum. A time frame assists in developing priorities: ‘what is important at *this time* of my life?’ or ‘what do I need to work on *now*?’

f) Ownership

Those with an internal locus of control often fare better than others according to the stress literature (Cooper, Sloan, & Williams, 1988). When setting outcomes, it is important that the coachee owns the outcomes. For example getting a pay rise is not in your control. However, achieving your targets this year and accepting an invitation to the boss’s barbecue could well be.

4. Meta Model

The Meta Model is the first model of NLP. It consists of 13 syntactic patterns in human speech along with the appropriate challenges. Questions assist a coachee to elaborate a hitherto impoverished map of the world, resulting in much greater choice.

A coach for example may facilitate change through the use of who, when, what, where, and how questions. In this way the coachee would recover much ‘lost’ information during the coaching process and have a richer, more elaborated map of their world as a result. This consequence puts the coachee in the position of having more choice. If ‘everyone hates me’ is challenged, and he/she arrives at the realization that in fact only their spouse hates them, then they immediately come to the realization that many people can now be approached, as it is only their spouse who hates them and not everyone else. Further Meta Model questions such as ‘how do you know your spouse hates you?’ may assist them to recognize that in fact their spouse does not hate, but loves them!

5. Milton Model

Just as the Meta Model uses language in order to challenge sentences which are not well formed and thus help represent the deep structure of reference experience, so conversely the Milton Model uses language in an ill-formed way with the purpose of overloading the conscious mind, so as to access the unconscious processes: 'You are sitting down in that chair and can begin to relax now'. The coachee cannot deny they are sitting in a chair; however the conjunction 'and' is used to link this irrefutable truth to a suggestion. The Milton Model uses the principle of utilization whereby the coachee's model of the world is maximally used, by accepting it, matching it, and pacing it. Because the nature of Milton Model language patterns is such that they are ill-formed, the conscious mind becomes overloaded, and access to the unconscious mind becomes possible. The utility of this is, as observed by Brooks (1922), if an idea is accepted by the unconscious mind it becomes a part of 'reality'. However, to accept something consciously is to accept it only analytically and for consideration.

6. Metaphor

Another Milton Model technique for the NLP coach is the use of metaphor, which has the effect again of bypassing the conscious mind. Just as humans replace objects with words, so too, using metaphor, the coach can replace the coachee's problem with another problem, within which lies a solution. A well-created metaphor will bypass the analytical mind and be accepted by the holistic mind of the unconscious, becoming a 'reality' for coachees, altering their experience and therefore their thinking, feeling and behaviour.

7. Anchoring

Anchor formats in NLP were developed by Bandler and Grinder as a result of modelling Erickson's style. They found that Erickson would use particular cues as post-hypnotic triggers to help a person change their internal state at some time in the future. If someone is, for example consistently irritated by another's behaviour it may be they have been anchored. Whenever this behaviour occurs they move into this predictable state. Anchoring is a natural phenomenon and is similar to classical conditioning (Dilts & DeLozier, 2000). Whereas in classical conditioning the conditional stimulus and conditional response were always external, anchoring formats have been generalized in NLP, and are used for internal events, too. In coaching therefore, the thought of giving a presentation can be anchored to a feeling of relaxation within the whole body.

8. Logical levels

The relevance of the logical levels model is that it overtly introduces the concept of systems thinking. The idea of logical levels was developed by Dilts (1990) and is loosely borrowed from

the concept of logical types formulated by Whitehead and Russell (1910) and used by Gregory Bateson (1972). According to the model there are six levels (spirit; identity; beliefs and values; capability; behaviour; and the environment). Each level synthesizes, organizes and directs the class of activity at the level below it. So changing something at a higher level will necessarily change something at a lower level; however, change at a lower level would not necessarily change the element above.

At an individual level there is a recognition that no behaviour stands alone. In order to understand a behaviour effectively one needs to understand where this behaviour occurs, when it occurs, how it occurs, what are the beliefs which underpin such behaviour, what values drive such behaviour, who would engage in such behaviour, and of what such behaviour is a part in the wider sense of shared and common behaviour. The logical levels model is thus a very useful content framework for exploring coachees' current maps of the world. With it they can understand how they are producing the results they are currently obtaining. This is a useful first stage in facilitating change at a particular level to obtain maximum leverage in the individual system.

9. Eye-accessing cues

In the film 'The Negotiator' the actor Samuel Jackson tells fellow hostages that he knows a group member is lying, because his eye movements went up and to the right when he spoke rather than up and to the left. The empirical evidence for the NLP design of eye-accessing cues seems very mixed. Eye movements may be related to several undefined sources of variance, and as a general rule the eye accessing cues posited by Dilts et al. (1980) need to be calibrated to each individual coachee. If every time the coachee talks about a particular problem they look down and to the right, and they do this consistently, according to the NLP model they are accessing a kinesthetic internal representation. Theoretically, they would respond much more quickly and accurately to the question 'and how do you feel about that?', compared with the questions 'how do you see that?' or 'how does that sound to you?'

Case study

Verna has requested coaching to help her cope with occupational stress. She had got to the point when she would have a panic attack if she met anyone from work. As rapport was built, she was encouraged to redevelop a reference experience (or anchor) of being very relaxed outside of work. This strategy for relaxation was made explicit in terms of sequencing representational systems and eliciting the sub-modalities. As Verna had a background in engineering and electronics, she enjoyed the 'small chunk' work of understanding how her own system was systematically put together.

The next stage involved systematic exploration of the difference between Verna's Meta Programmes (loosely speaking the NLP term for personality), and those explicit in the organization. Certain triggers were identified that made her 'run' a very different programme.

In comparing these programmes Verna was able to see how she was literally creating different experiences for herself. She called these insights 'Condor moments'. By the sixth session Verna was automatically representing herself as a much more relaxed professional when talking and engaging with people at work. To secure this result the old stress strategy was visualized and then replaced by the new relaxation strategy.

EVALUATION

NLP is at a stage where evaluation of its methodology is largely anecdotal. However, there is movement currently to evaluate NLP in a much more robust way, both quantitatively and qualitatively. Many of the increasingly empirical studies of NLP can be found at the website <http://www.nlp.de/cgi-bin/research/nlp-rdb.cgi>. These are mainly student dissertations and thus characterize well the present state of research into NLP. However, Tosey and Mathison are conducting one of the first funded, university-based research projects into NLP. The project started in November 2005. For those interested in the evaluation of NLP using qualitative paradigms as well as quantitative, the project can be found at <http://www.nlpresearch.org/>

The current state of research into the use of the NLP approach in coaching is weak and will not impress those who have a need for evidence. It also may not be the best approach for clients who wish to be kept fully informed as to what is going on and who wish to work overtly in a step-by-step fashion. NLP coaches often use many of the described skills working simultaneously at engaging the conscious mind in order to communicate with the unconscious mind where facilitative change occurs. Finally, as NLP is an approach that emphasizes the need to work at the level pattern and process, clients who wish for in-depth conversations concerning the content of their situations may find NLP coaches unsuitable for them. At the same time, consistent interest in this approach seems to support the view that clients do benefit from it.

APPLICATION TO SPECIFIC COACHING CONTEXTS AND GENRES

Currently, NLP coaching is used in almost every coaching context, and this reflects the flexibility of the approach. Having an affinity with behaviourism, it is ideally suited to skills and performance coaching, and with its underlying philosophy of personal responsibility for the maps which govern our experience, it can easily be used within the context of developmental coaching. NLP coaching, which has the consistent theme of systems thinking supporting its presuppositions and change techniques, is well-suited to executive and leadership coaching. At an individual level, perspectives can be challenged and developed. At an organizational level the systemic nature of interactions between and within departments and divisions can readily be represented and then developed using NLP coaching. This is increasingly important, as Peter Senge (1990) points out: system thinking allows organizations to focus on the cause

rather than the symptoms and provide long-term solutions rather than short symptomatic quick fixes.

As NLP coaching puts such emphasis on rapport, many life coaches find its personable paradigm well buttressed with a richness of philosophy and techniques. This allows them to develop their coaching style effectively and without constraints on their own personality. If a coach has a preference for detail, they will enjoy coaching using the Meta Model. Alternatively, a coach who prefers to look at the bigger picture will enjoy making use of the Milton Model in their coaching approach. Coaches who deal with cross-cultural issues find NLP coaching very useful because the Meta Model assists clients in developing an awareness of their own cultural values, beliefs and attitudes. It shows how these can be effectively represented in differing cultural contexts in an elegant manner. The Meta Model is specifically useful for assisting such clients to examine their own unexplored assumptions and stereotypes about the behaviours of those in other cultures.

When coaching in a specific competency is called for either in an executive or managerial role, NLP is ideal because of the emphasis on integration of the skills into an unconsciously competent format. For instance anchoring is something that consistently and naturally occurs; one cannot avoid anchoring. The NLP coach is simply a professional person who is aware of the ubiquitous nature of such a process and will use it in an ethical way. This means that integration of NLP coaching skills into an executive or managerial role is seamless and does not create resistance in those being coached. Often, issues of fit come to the fore in both team and career coaching. NLP places great emphasis on goal setting and creating frames that work for individuals and teams; however, it also places an equal emphasis on the mind–body system and the need for ecology and congruence in the lives of those who seek to work as part of a team or to develop their career.

FURTHER READING

- Dilts, R., & DeLozier, J. (2000). *Encyclopedia of Systemic Neuro-Linguistic Programming and NLP New Coding*. NLP University Press. (A major work in two volumes, covering everything in NLP.)
- DeLozier, J., & Grinder, J. (1987) *Turtles all the way down*. Grinder and Associates. (A chance to experience the 'Spirit of NLP' in this record of a five-day NLP seminar on prerequisites to personal genius.)
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